WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO BE AN UNTOUCHABLE?

Rs 395

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navayana

Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (1891–1956), one of India's foremost revolutionaries, grew up untouchable. Battling against the odds, he gained multiple doctorates, campaigned against social discrimination and the caste system and went on to draft the Constitution of India. Throughout his life Ambedkar faced routine discrimination: in school at the age of 10; in Baroda after his return from Columbia University; and while travelling in later life. The discrimination experienced by Ambedkar continues to haunt a majority of India's 170 million dalits as many are still denied water, shelter and the basic dignities of life.

In this ground-breaking work, Pardhan Gond artists Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam interweave historical events with contemporary incidents, infusing fresh energy into the graphic idiom through their magical art.

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India's top selling graphic book published in Telugu, Tamil, Hindi, Marathi, Kannada, Malayalam, French, Korean and Spanish

BHIMAYANA

incidents in the life of

BHIMRAO RAMJI AMBEDKAR

art

DURGABAI VYAM, SUBHASH VYAM

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navayana

FOREWORD

I want to try to say something about the way this extraordinary book tells its story.

During the 19th and 20th centuries History was confronted and visualized as a stage: a stage on which women and men struggled to choose and achieve their destiny and a life in which there was more justice; their struggles were inspired and accompanied by the words of visionaries, political thinkers and active politicians, some of them wielding power, others subversive. Such an Historical stage with its proscenium arch, its regular seats set out as in an amphitheatre, its dramatic lighting and acoustics, was present in poems, written stories, political meetings, insurrections, songs, shared dreams. Today no longer.

The imagined theatre has been destroyed by so-called Communication Experts, the media, politicians without a future, and a global economic system which reduces the whole of History and every horizon of life to the pursuit of profit. On the site of the stage there is today a Shopping Mall.

Yet, in fact, History continues and the struggles persist. And so we face the challenge of how to tell stories about them across the world today.

This book offers a prophetic answer and it is this: replace the stage of History with the Body of a community. A body with a long past, a present of many voices, and a vision of the future. Reading the book and following its story, we enter this body, its bloodstream, its organs, its members.

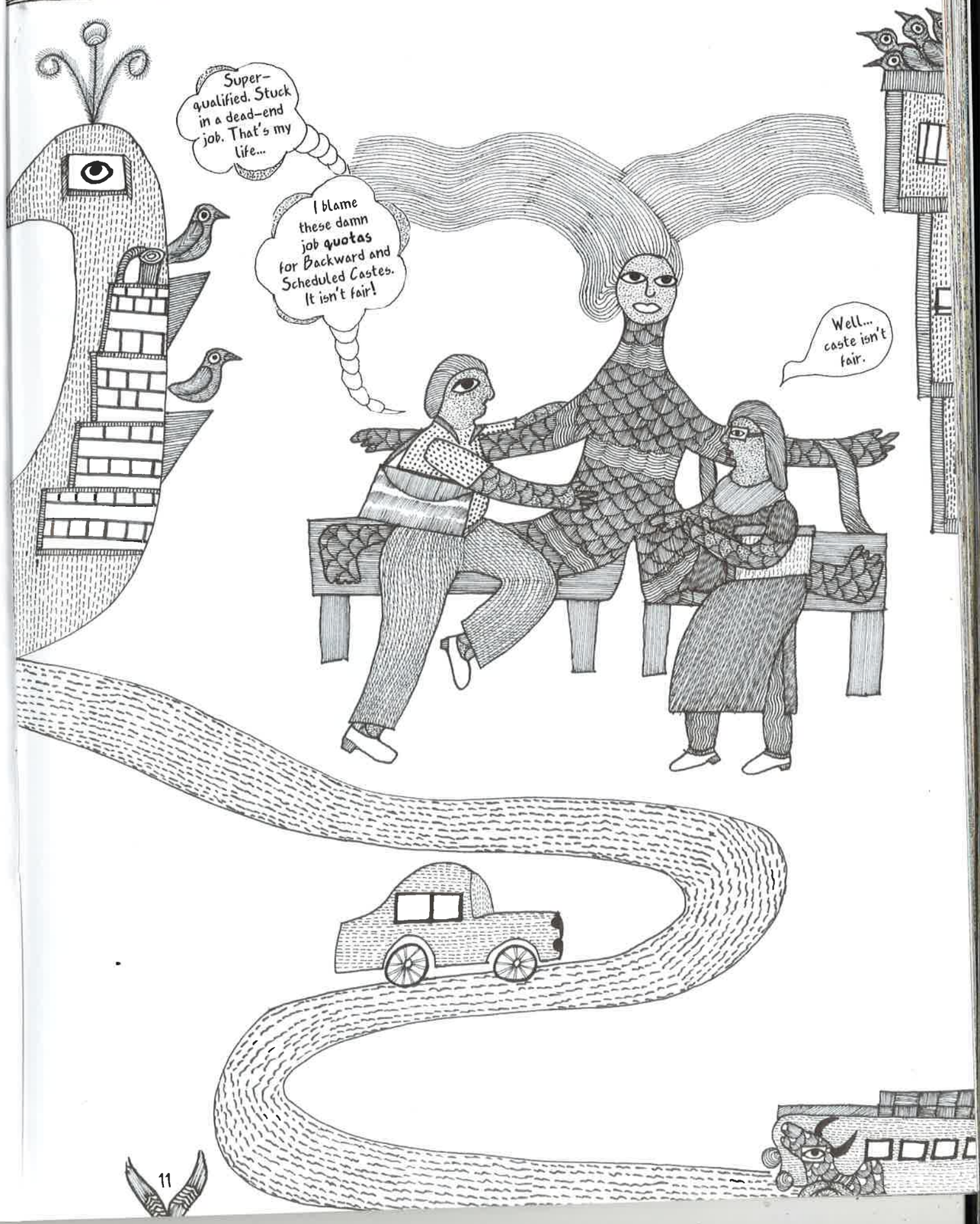
No more proscenium arch. No more rectangular framing or unilinear time. No more profiled individuals. Instead, a conference of corporeal experience across generations, full of pain and empathy, and nurtured by a complicity and endurance that can outlive the Market.

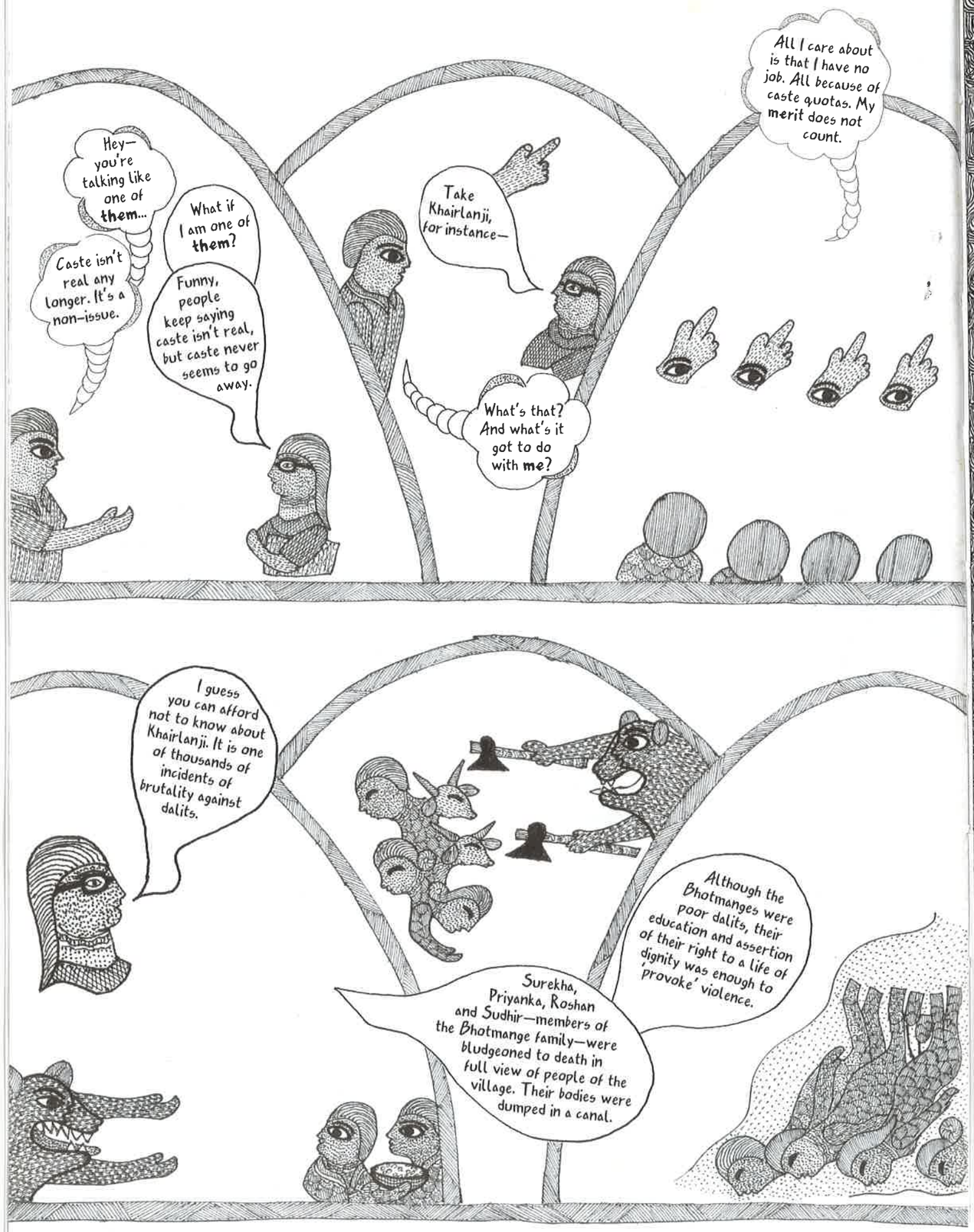
Stories are being told like this all over the world. They are seldom printed and published. This book has now set an example.

Let us thank everyone who contributed to it for that example.

JOHN BERGER
26 July 2010
Taninges, France

ONE DAY IN THE RECENT PAST, A BUS STOP IN AN INDIAN CITY...





TENSION AFTER DALITS DRAW WATER FROM WELL

KOLHAPUR, HINDUSTAN TIMES, 29 SEPT 2010

On the face of it, Ghungurwadi village in Shahuwadi Taluk, Maharashtra, named after social reformer King Rajashri Shahu Maharaj, should be setting an example for the upliftment of the socially downtrodden. But dalits here are still subjected to discrimination. On September 20, one act of the dalits from Ghungur put an end to nearly 60 years of discrimination. Narsu Kamble, his cousin Sugriv Kamble, along with several other members of the community, fetched drinking water from a well meant for the Marathas. Irked, members of the upper caste denounced the act and boycotted the water from the well.

HONOUR KILLING SHOCKS THE CAPITAL

NEW DELHI, MAIL TODAY, 15 JUNE 2010

In an incident that could send shockwaves across the **Capital**, a 19-year-old girl and her boyfriend were allegedly **bludgeoned and electrocuted to death** by her family in Swaroop Nagar in north-west Delhi around midnight on Sunday. Asha Saini and her [dalit] boyfriend Yogesh Jatav (also 19) were kept away from each other by the girl's family after their relationship was discovered. Both were reportedly from different castes. Asha, a resident of Gokulpuri in north-east Delhi, was sent to her uncle Om Prakash's house in Swaroop Nagar around a fortnight ago but Yogesh managed to somehow meet his girlfriend on Sunday night.

JUST ANOTHER RAPE STORY

SABRINA BUCKWALTER

TIMES OF INDIA, 29 OCT 2006

The village of **Khairlanji**, near Nagpur, is an unremarkable settlement of brick huts and cement houses. Less than 200 families live here. Dirt roads run between flat farmlands, and the eye sees great sprawling distances. There was always a gaping silence in this village, even before September 29 when an upper caste mob, according to eyewitnesses, paraded a mother and her 17-year-old daughter naked, raped and killed them. Two other members of the family, brothers aged 19 and 21, too were murdered. Their bodies were dumped in a canal. Thirty-eight men have been arrested and they are being held in police custody. The gruesome incident occurred **180 km from Mumbai**, too far out it appears to muster national outrage. The news of this brutality did not enter the mainstream news in any significant fashion...

ROW OVER 'UNTOUCHABLE' INDIAN DOG

MORENA (MADHYA PRADESH), BBC NEWS, 24 SEPT 201

Police in India are investigating claims that a dalit woman has been ordered to pay compensation to the high-caste owners of a dog she fed. The woman says the village council wants her to pay a fine of 15,000 rupees ($330) for feeding the dog, which the owners have now kicked out. The incident took place in Malikpur village in Morena district in central Madhya Pradesh state. "I made some roti and took it to the dog. After I had fed him, my husband who works in a farm, gave me some leftovers which I gave to the dog," said Sunita Jatav, a dalit woman. She said the incident took place on Sunday evening from the truck of Balbir Kirari, who has a transport business in the village. "We had some leftovers and together we had fed the dog. Her husband said 'You've fed my dog, and together, both of us become untouchable now'." Mrs Jatav said Mr Kirari left the dog, a black mongrel called Sheru, tied to a pole outside her house. On Monday, [illegible]

Two dalit teenagers were assaulted, tied with ropes and then dragged for several meters by a group of villagers in Uttar Pradesh's Rae Bareli district on charges of **stealing a mobile phone** kept in a vehicle, police said Monday. Ajai Nat (15) and Ravishankar Raidas (14), residents of Lachminia village, some 80 km from Lucknow, were accused of stealing a mobile phone on Sunday evening from the truck of Balbir Singh, who has a transport business in the village. When Singh failed to recover the mobile from the [illegible] he called three of his associates, and together beat up the teenagers with wooden sticks and also shaved their heads. Thereafter, both the teenagers were tied with ropes and dragged for several meters in the village. "We came to know about the incident on [illegible]

DALIT KILLED FOR DEMANDING WAGE

A dalit in a Madhya Pradesh village only wanted payment of wages due to him—but what he got was death. Mason Ramesh Jatav was allegedly killed after [illegible]

TIMES OF INDIA

Untouchability Live & Kicking in India's Schools

Dalits Have Little Access To Temples, Their Kids Are Made To Sit Separately In Schools

THE TIMES OF INDIA, NEW DELHI
MONDAY, AUGUST 3, 2009

AMBEDKAR: HIS STATUES OUTNUMBER GANDHI'S AND NEHRU'S, BUT FEW PEOPLE KNOW ABOUT HIS LIFE OR WORK...

I'd read **Ambedkar** if I were you. I'd want to understand what happened in Khairlanji, and why two dalits are killed every day in India.

Amb-ed-who? The guy in all those **statues**?

ON 14 APRIL 1891, HE WAS BORN INTO A MAHAR FAMILY, THE FOURTEENTH CHILD OF BHIMABAI AND RAMJI SAKPAL.

And a **mahar** is...?

I forgot— you're from the South. People of the mahar caste were among the untouchables in western India, like paraiyars and malas in the South,

GOING THROUGH THE VILLAGE EVERY DAY TO CLEAN OUT ITS FILTH,

LIVING ON THE EDGE OF THE VILLAGE,

DOING LABOUR FOR WHICH THEY COULD EXPECT NO PAYMENT...

This was how dalits across India lived for a long, long time...

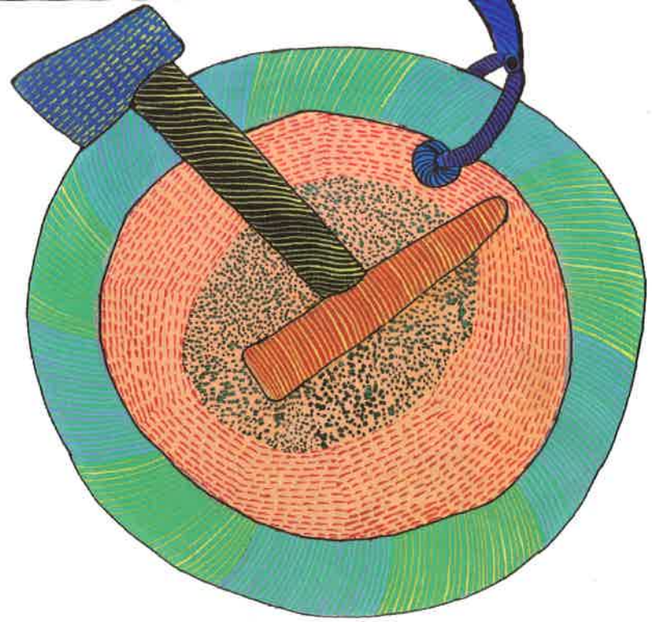
BUYING SPICES AND OIL AT HINDU SHOPS STANDING OUTSIDE THE DOOR...

COLLECTING LEFTOVERS AT THE BACKDOORS OF HINDU HOUSES...

RUNNING ERRANDS FOR THE VILLAGE FOLK...

YOUNG **BHIM AMBEDKAR** WAS NOT THE WORST OFF AMONG THEM, BUT HE LEARNT BITTER LESSONS ABOUT CASTE.

BOOK



WATER

1901. A SCHOOL IN SATARA, A TOWN IN WESTERN INDIA.

Join us?

But I'm not supposed to!

10-YEAR-OLD BHIM SITS APART. HE'S THINKING OF THE BELL...

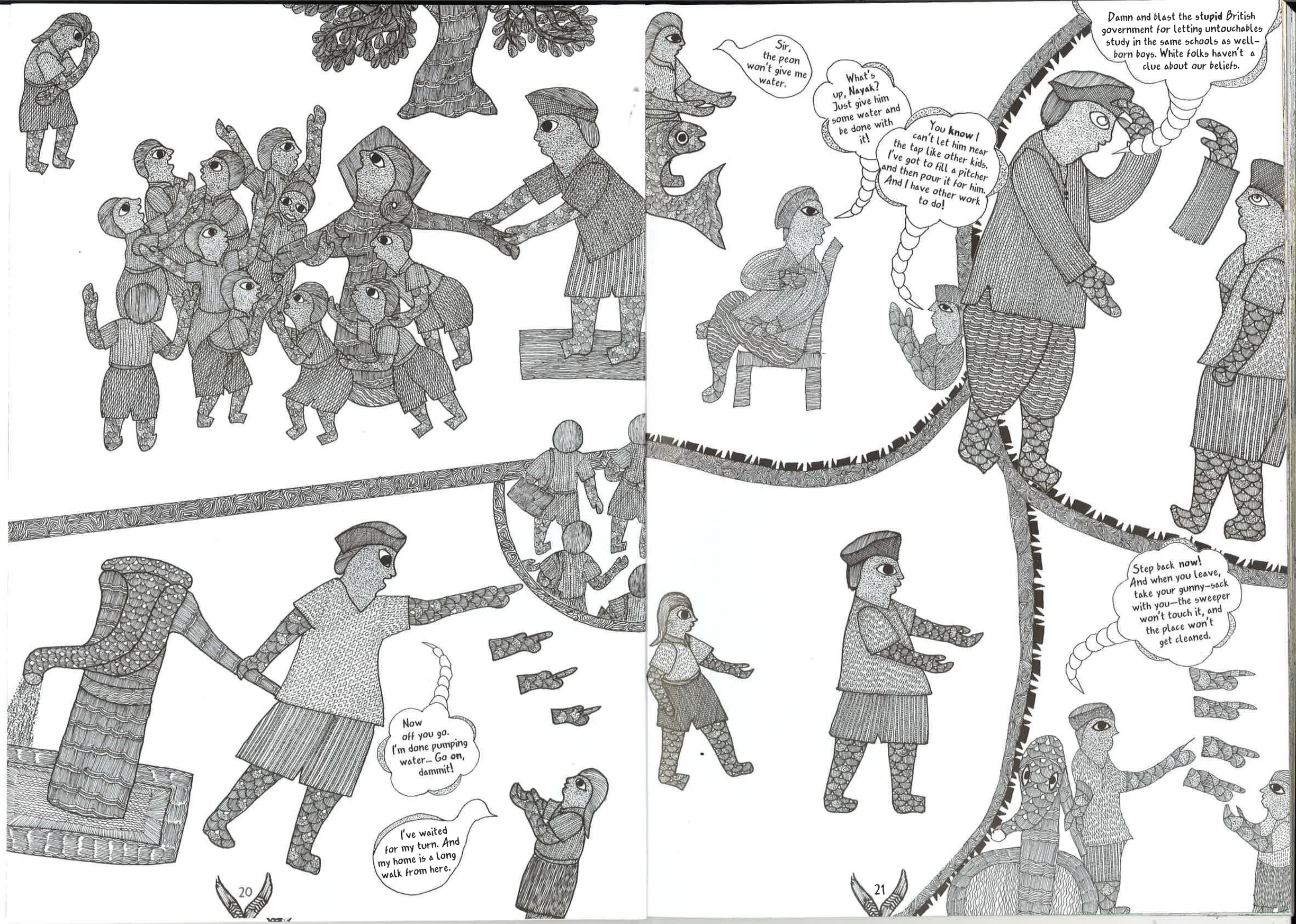
Sir, may I drink some water?

Bhim! Always a nuisance! Can't you wait until the bell rings?

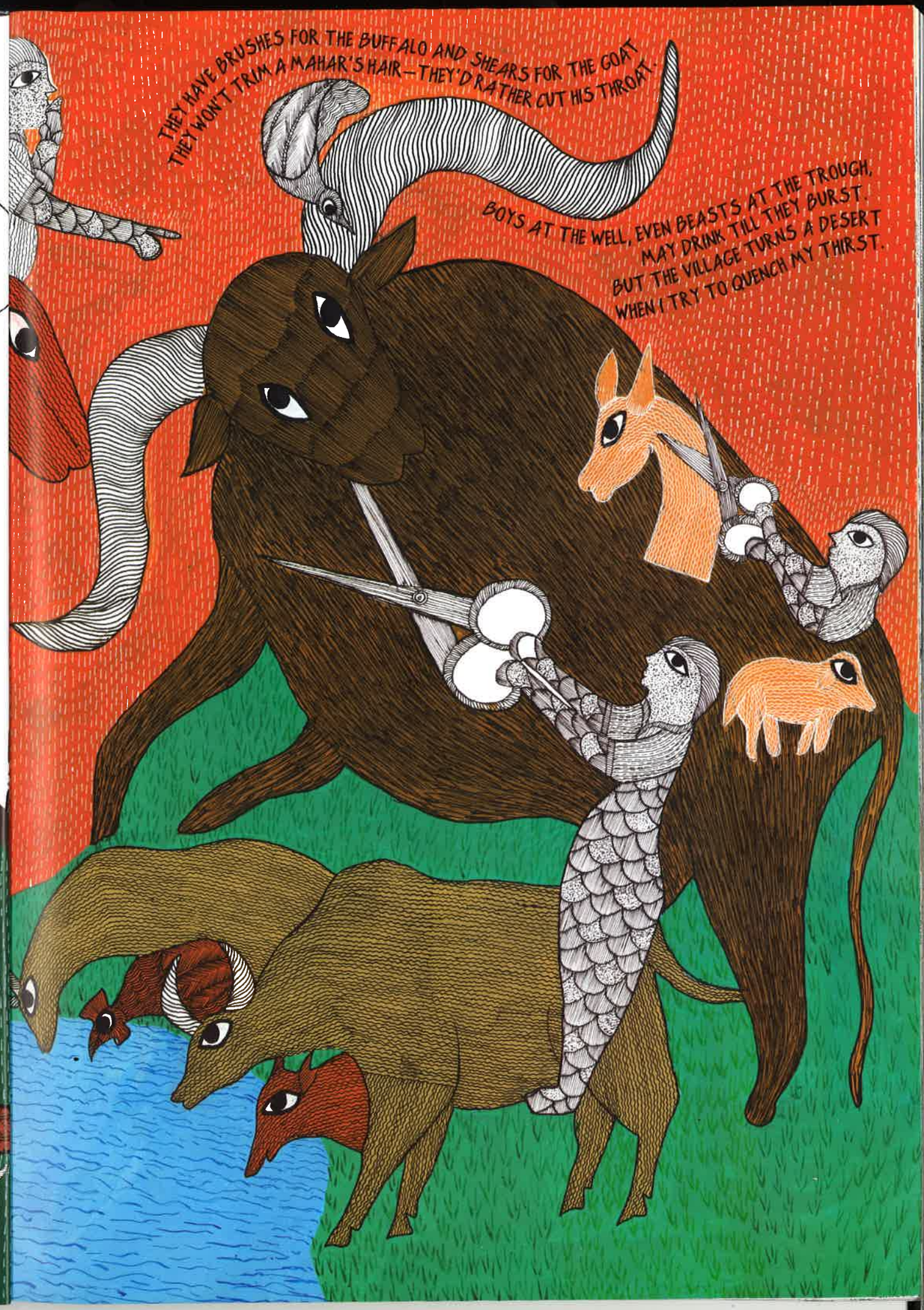
When the bell rings, all the other students go to the tap. By the time they finish, the peon has gone home. And I'm not supposed to touch the tap.

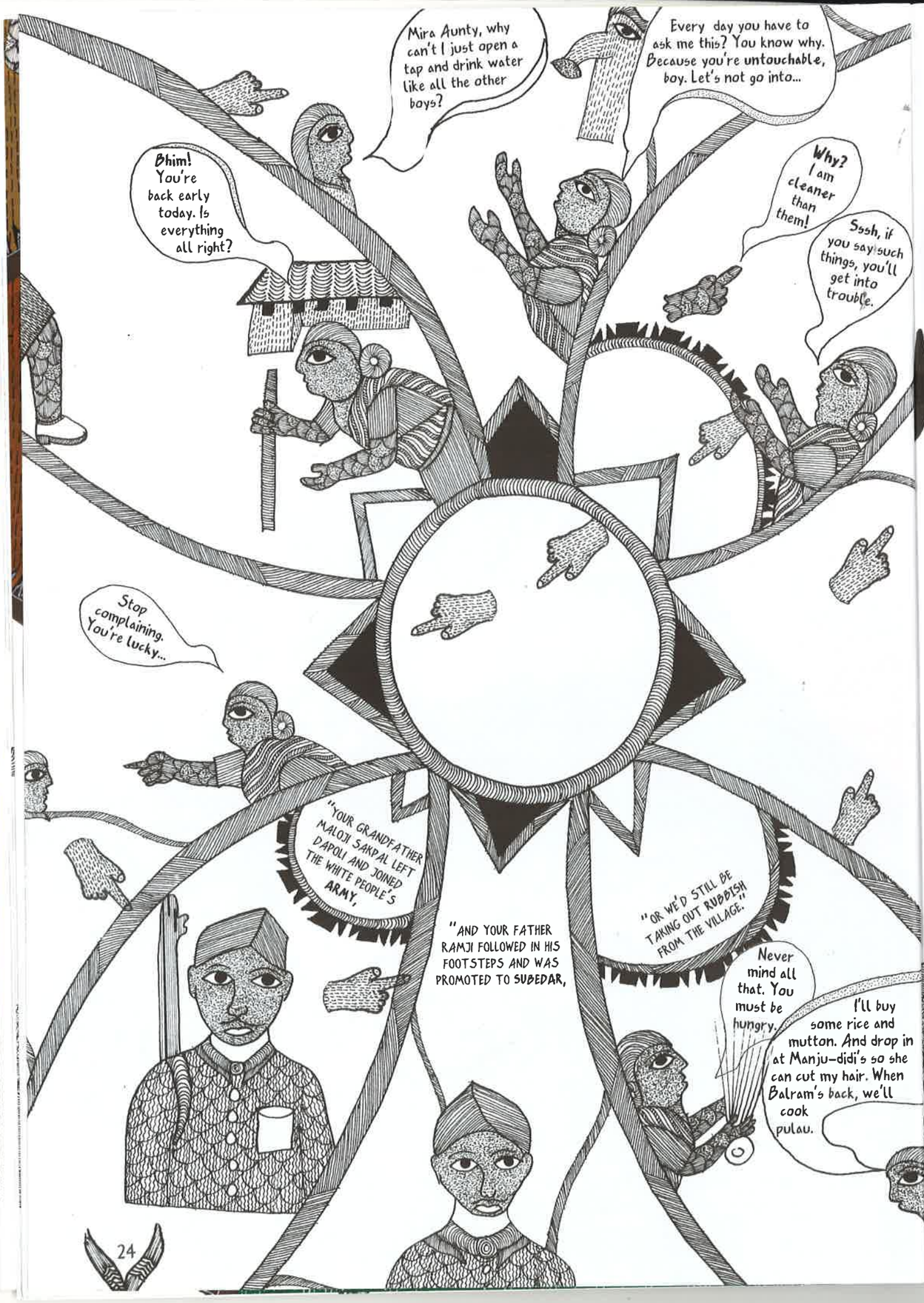
Well, naturally. You're a **mahar!** If you cut your hair more often, you'd feel less thirsty. You look as if there are no barbers in Satara.

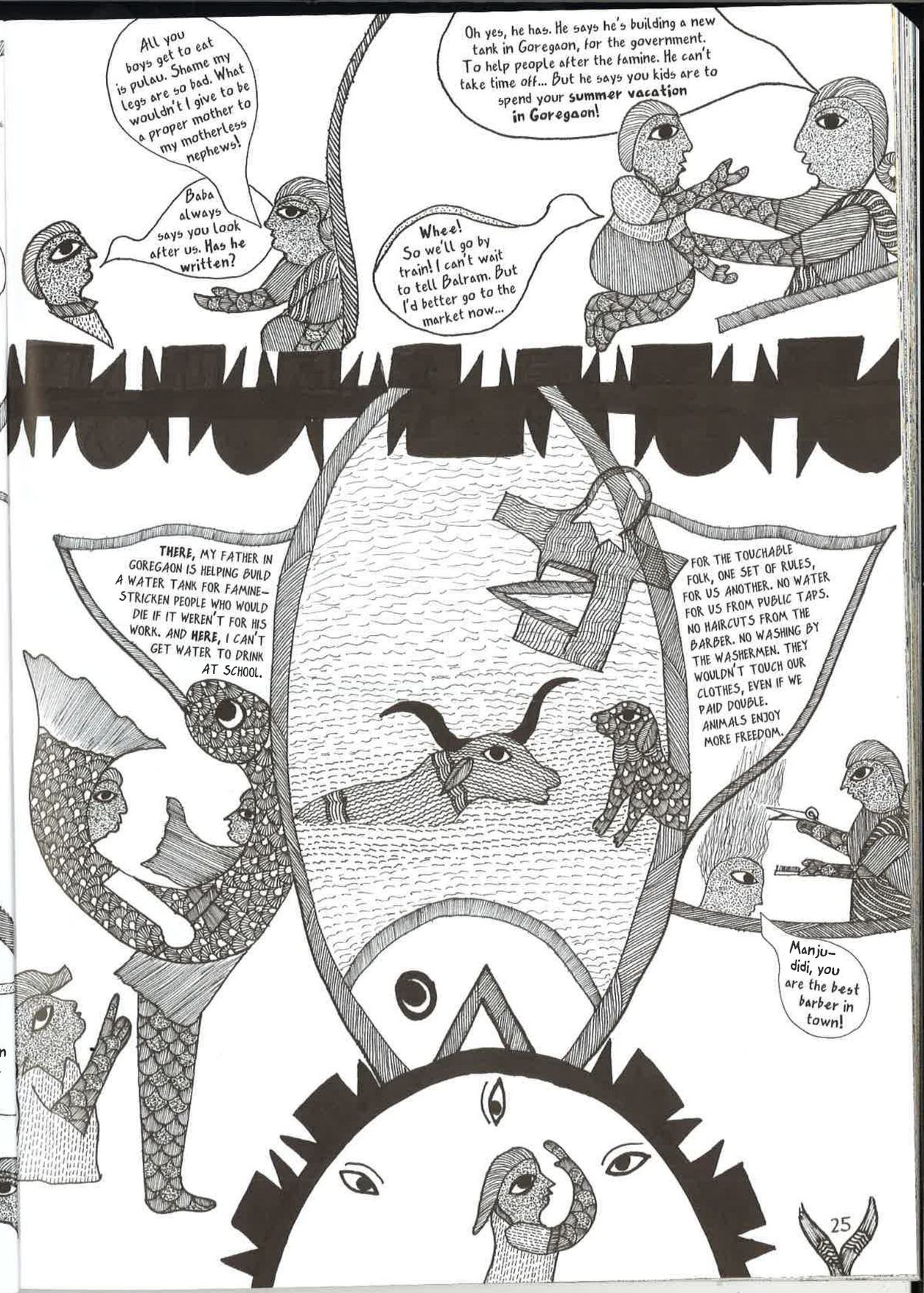
But doesn't he **know**? Barbers won't **touch** us mahars....


Sir, the peon won't give me water.
What's up, Nayak? Just give him some water and be done with it!
You know I can't let him near the tap like other kids. I've got to fill a pitcher and then pour it for him. And I have other work to do!
Damn and blast the stupid British government for letting untouchables study in the same schools as well-born boys. White folks haven't a clue about our beliefs.
Now off you go. I'm done pumping water... Go on, dammit!
I've waited for my turn. And my home is a long walk from here.
Step back now! And when you leave, take your gunny-sack with you—the sweeper won't touch it, and the place won't get cleaned.

*From Namdeo Dhasal's "Water" in Golpitha. Trans. from the Marathi by Dilip Chitre




Bhim! You're back early today. Is everything all right?
Mira Aunty, why can't I just open a tap and drink water like all the other boys?
Every day you have to ask me this? You know why. Because you're untouchable, boy. Let's not go into...
Why? I am cleaner than them!
Ssssh, if you say such things, you'll get into trouble.
Stop complaining. You're lucky...
"YOUR GRANDFATHER MALOJI SAKPAL LEFT DAPOLI AND JOINED THE WHITE PEOPLE'S ARMY,
"AND YOUR FATHER RAMJI FOLLOWED IN HIS FOOTSTEPS AND WAS PROMOTED TO SUBEDAR,
"OR WE'D STILL BE TAKING OUT RUBBISH FROM THE VILLAGE."
Never mind all that. You must be hungry.
I'll buy some rice and mutton. And drop in at Manju-didi's so she can cut my hair. When Balram's back, we'll cook pulau.


All you boys get to eat is pulau. Shame my legs are so bad. What wouldn't I give to be a proper mother to my motherless nephews!
Baba always says you look after us. Has he written?
Oh yes, he has. He says he's building a new tank in Goregaon, for the government. To help people after the famine. He can't take time off... But he says you kids are to spend your summer vacation in Goregaon!
Whee! So we'll go by train! I can't wait to tell Balram. But I'd better go to the market now...
THERE, MY FATHER IN GOREGAON IS HELPING BUILD A WATER TANK FOR FAMINE-STRICKEN PEOPLE WHO WOULD DIE IF IT WEREN'T FOR HIS WORK. AND HERE, I CAN'T GET WATER TO DRINK AT SCHOOL.
FOR THE TOUCHABLE FOLK, ONE SET OF RULES, FOR US ANOTHER. NO WATER FOR US FROM PUBLIC TAPS. NO HAIRCUTS FROM THE BARBER. NO WASHING BY THE WASHERMEN. THEY WOULDN'T TOUCH OUR CLOTHES, EVEN IF WE PAID DOUBLE. ANIMALS ENJOY MORE FREEDOM.
Manju-didi, you are the best barber in town!